

Iceland in November Cheat Sheet

Wind, ice, and darkness — the layering system, the microspikes call, and the bag-size math on one page.

CONDITIONS

Temperature (Reykjavik / south coast)	28-41°F (-2 to 5°C) — wind chill makes it feel far colder
Daylight	~8 hours early November, ~5 by the end
The real hazards	wind, freeze-thaw ice, and darkness — not raw cold

THE LAYERING SYSTEM (BEATS A HEAVY PARKA)

Base layers (no cotton)	2-3 tops, 1-2 bottoms — merino or synthetic
Mid layer	1 warm fleece or light insulated jacket
Shell	waterproof + windproof, hooded — non-negotiable
Pants	2-3 travel pants (jeans are not a primary option)
Boots	waterproof, worn on the plane
Warm accessories	beanie, gloves, buff — wind demands all three
Microspikes	slip-on traction — the item first-timers regret skipping
Swimsuit + quick-dry towel	hot springs are a November highlight
Headlamp or phone lamp	dark starts and ends to every day

RULES THAT SAVE THE TRIP

- No cotton base layers, no jeans as primary pants, no umbrella — Icelandic wind punishes all three.
- Wear boots, base, fleece, and shell on the plane — that habit alone moves 8-10L out of the bag.
- Aurora photographers: the tripod decision determines your bag class more than any clothing choice.

THE BAG-SIZE MATH

- Efficient setups run 38-50L. Carry-on is achievable for disciplined packers — one of the harder months.
- Checking a bag is a reasonable choice for a trip this gear-heavy, especially with camera gear.